RELATIONSHIPS

Friendship Flags Checklist

How to recognize healthy friendships, red flags, and everything in between

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A Note from Dr. Hala

Dear reader,

Friendships shape your life more than most people realize. The people you surround yourself with influence your mood, your self-esteem, your decisions, and even your future. But not all friendships are created equal, and not all of them are good for you.

This checklist is designed to help you evaluate your friendships with clarity and compassion. It is not about cutting people off at the first sign of trouble. It is about understanding what healthy connection looks like so you can invest your energy wisely.

With warmth, **Dr. Hala Ali** *Family & Youth Counselor*

Section 1: Green Flags in Friendships

These are signs that a friendship is healthy and worth nurturing.

- [ ] They celebrate your wins without jealousy
- [ ] You can be yourself around them without performing
- [ ] They respect your boundaries when you say no
- [ ] They check on you, not just when they need something
- [ ] Conversations go both ways, they listen as much as they talk
- [ ] They apologize when they mess up, sincerely
- [ ] You feel energized, not drained, after spending time together
- [ ] They keep your secrets and respect your privacy
- [ ] They support your growth even when it means you are changing
- [ ] Disagreements are handled with respect, not manipulation

Reflection

How many of these describe your closest friendship? If most of them apply, you have something worth protecting.

Section 2: Yellow Flags to Watch

These are not dealbreakers, but they are worth paying attention to.

- [ ] They cancel plans frequently without explanation
- [ ] They only reach out when they need something
- [ ] They make jokes at your expense and call it humor
- [ ] They are hot and cold, super close one week, distant the next
- [ ] They gossip about others to you (which means they gossip about you to others)
- [ ] They compete with you instead of supporting you
- [ ] They dismiss your feelings with phrases like "you are overreacting"
- [ ] They pressure you to do things you are not comfortable with
- [ ] They get upset when you spend time with other people
- [ ] You find yourself making excuses for their behavior

Reflection

Yellow flags do not mean you should end the friendship immediately. They mean you should pay attention and potentially have an honest conversation about what you need.

Section 3: Red Flags That Demand Action

These are signs that a friendship is harmful and may need to end.

- [ ] They manipulate you emotionally to get what they want
- [ ] They share your private information with others
- [ ] They put you down consistently, in private or in public
- [ ] They try to isolate you from other friends or family
- [ ] They use guilt to control your behavior
- [ ] They are physically intimidating or aggressive
- [ ] They pressure you into illegal or dangerous activities
- [ ] They refuse to take responsibility for hurting you
- [ ] You feel worse about yourself because of this friendship

- [ ] You feel afraid of their reaction if you set a boundary

Reflection

If you checked even two or three of these, this friendship may be causing real harm. You deserve better, and seeking support to navigate this is not weakness.

Section 4: How to Have the Conversation

If You Need to Set a Boundary

"I value our friendship, and I need to be honest about something that has been bothering me. When [specific behavior], I feel [specific emotion]. Can we talk about this?"

If You Need to Step Back

"I have been doing some thinking about what I need right now, and I need to take some space. This is not about blame. It is about taking care of myself."

If You Need to End It

Not every friendship needs a dramatic ending. Sometimes the healthiest thing is to gradually reduce contact and invest your energy elsewhere. You do not owe anyone a friendship that costs you your peace.

Ready for Personalized Support?

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